一枚邮票改变通信

The Stamp That Changed the Post



一枚邮票怎样简化寄信，又怎样防止重复使用？

READ 纯净阅读

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RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

Before 1840, British postage was levied according to the number of sheets in a letter and the mileage of its carriage. The sum was usually payable on delivery, so the person receiving the correspondence, not the sender, settled it. Prices thus fluctuated from one postal item to the next.

In 1837 Rowland Hill published a booklet urging reform. Parliament enacted the campaigner's proposal in 1839, and on 10 January 1840 the Uniform Penny Post began. A letter of up to half an ounce now cost one penny to any destination in Britain, and the fee was prepaid by whoever sent it. One flat-rate charge replaced variation with simplicity.

The Penny Black, a one-penny denomination, was released on 1 May 1840, its validity starting on 6 May. Engraved on it was a youthful likeness of Queen Victoria, the reigning monarch. An aggregate of 68,808,000 were printed. The sheets had no holes for separation, so each stamp was cut out individually with scissors.

Mailings doubled, from about 80 million items in 1839 to over 169 million in 1840. The design had a drawback. Against black, the red cancelling mark was barely noticeable, lacking contrast, and the ink could be erased, leaving stamps vulnerable to reuse. In February 1841 the Penny Red, cancelled in black ink, arrived to deter tampering and fraud.

As the initiator of postage stamps, Britain set a precedent and earned an exemption. Its stamps are nameless, with no country inscribed on them. By international agreement, the sovereign's head suffices for identification, an implicit designation that other countries spell out in print.

中文译文

1840年以前，英国邮费按信内纸张数量与运输里程收取，通常在投递时付款。因此，结清邮费的往往是收信人，而非寄信人，每件邮件的价格也不相同。

1837年，罗兰·希尔出版小册子，呼吁改革。议会于1839年通过了他的提议，统一便士邮资在1840年1月10日开始实行：半盎司（约14克）以内的信，寄往英国境内任何地方都只收一便士，由寄信人预付。一项统一费率让原来各不相同的收费变得简单。

面值一便士的黑便士邮票于1840年5月1日发行，5月6日起可用于邮寄。邮票上刻有当时在位君主维多利亚女王的年轻肖像，共印制68,808,000枚。整版邮票没有用来分开的齿孔，每一枚都要用剪刀单独剪下。

邮寄量翻了一番，从1839年的约8000万件增加至1840年的1.69亿多件。但设计也有缺点：红色盖销印在黑底上缺少反差，很不显眼，而且红色墨迹能被擦掉，邮票因此容易被重复使用。1841年2月，改用黑色墨水盖销的红便士邮票问世，以阻止篡改和欺诈。

英国作为邮票首创国，开创先例，也获得一项特例：邮票上可以不印国名。按照国际协议，只凭君主头像就足以识别国家；这是一种隐含的国家标识，其他国家则需要把国名直接印出来。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

postage n.
邮费
British postage was levied

levy v.
征收
levied according to the number

mileage n.
里程
the mileage of its carriage

payable adj.
应支付的
usually payable on delivery

correspondence n.
信件
receiving the correspondence

fluctuate v.
波动；各不相同
Prices thus fluctuated

enact v.
立法通过
Parliament enacted

proposal n.
提议；方案
the campaigner's proposal

prepay v.
预付
the fee was prepaid

flat-rate charge 名词短语
统一费率收费
One flat-rate charge

denomination n.
面值
a one-penny denomination

validity n.
效力；有效期
its validity starting on 6 May

aggregate n.
总计；总数
aggregate of 68,808,000

mailing n.
邮寄件数；邮件
Mailings doubled

drawback n.
缺点
The design had a drawback

cancelling mark 名词短语
邮票盖销印记
the red cancelling mark

contrast n.
反差
lacking contrast

vulnerable to 形容词短语
容易遭到；易受……影响
vulnerable to reuse

deter v.
阻止；遏制
to deter tampering and fraud

fraud n.
欺诈
to deter tampering and fraud

precedent n.
先例
Britain set a precedent

exemption n.
豁免；特例
earned an exemption

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共34项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

sheet n.
纸张

carriage n.
运输

delivery n.
投递

sender n.
寄信人

postal adj.
邮政的

item n.
一件邮件；物品

booklet n.
小册子

campaigner n.
改革倡导者

ounce n.
盎司

penny n.
便士

destination n.
目的地

variation n.
差异；变化

simplicity n.
简便

engrave v.
雕刻；刻印

youthful adj.
年轻的

likeness n.
肖像

reigning adj.
在位的

monarch n.
君主

separation n.
分离

individually adv.
单独地

scissors n.
剪刀

item n.
一件件邮件；物品

noticeable adj.
显眼的

erase v.
擦除

reuse n.
重复使用

tampering n.
篡改；擅自改动

initiator n.
首创者；发起者

nameless adj.
此处指未印国名的

inscribe v.
刻印

sovereign n.
君主

suffice for 动词短语
足以用于

identification n.
识别

implicit adj.
隐含的

designation n.
标识；名称

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 and the fee was _____ by whoever sent it.

02 An _____ of 68,808,000 were printed.

03 The design had a _____.

04 Britain set a precedent and earned an _____.

文章主线

- 旧制 英国邮费原按信纸数量和运输距离计算，通常由收信人付款，每封信的价格不一。
- 改革 1840年1月起，希尔推动的改革让半盎司（约14克）以内的信在英国境内统一收一便士，由寄件人预付。
- 邮票 同年5月发行印有维多利亚女王头像的黑便士；当年邮寄量由上年约8000万件增至1.69亿多件。
- 改进 黑便士上的红色邮戳不显眼，红戳又可擦掉，使邮票容易被重用；1841年改发红便士并盖黑戳防重用。
- 特例 英国因首创邮票获国际特例，可不印国名，以君主头像标明国家；其他国家则要把国名印出。

参考答案　1 prepaid 2 aggregate 3 drawback 4 exemption